Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?

By Edward Albee

MARTHA: **(Pg 15-16)** Poor Georgie-Porgie, put-upon pie! *[as he sulks]* Awww. . . what are you doing? Are you sulking? Hunh? Let me see. . . are you sulking? Is that what you're doing?

GEORGE: *[very quietly]* Never mind, Martha. . .

MARTHA: AWWWWWWWWW! *[no reaction]* Hey! *[no reaction]* HEY! *[GEORGE looks at her, put-upon - she sings to the tune of *Who's Afraid of the Big Bad Wolf]* "Who's afraid of Virginia Woolf, Virginia Woolf, Virginia Woolf. . . Ha, ha, ha, Ha!" *[no reaction]* What's the matter . . . didn't you think that was funny? Hunh?

GEORGE: *[patiently]* It was very funny; yes. **(Pg 18)** Just don't start in on the bit about the kid, that's all.

MARTHA: **(Pg 16)** *[after a moment's consideration]* You make me puke! **(Pg 19)** *[threatening]* He's mine as much as he is yours. I'll talk about him if I want to.

GEORGE: I'd advise against it, Martha.

MARTHA: SCREW you!

INTRODUCTION

Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf? explores a marriage steeped in manipulation and emotional abuse. George and Martha's innocent banter quickly pivots to a bitter and venomous exchange, especially when the topic of their thinly veiled psychological warfare turns to their son. As the truth is revealed, the painful illusions that sustain a toxic relationship are finally exposed. Can they – can anyone – survive a life built on deception?

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MARTHA: **(Pg 49)** *[to audience]* George's biggest problem about . . . ha, ha, ha, HA! . . . about our son, is that deep down in the private-most pit of his gut, he's not completely sure it's his own kid.

GEORGE: *[deeply serious]* My God, you're a wicked woman. *[to audience]* Martha's lying. *[MARTHA laughs]* the one thing in this whole sinking world that I am sure of is my

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partnership in the . . . creation of our . . . son. **(Pg 55-56)** I warn you, Martha, it's going to make me angry.

MARTHA: *[laughing at him]* Oh, it is, is it?

GEORGE: *[very quietly]* I warn you. *[turns his back to her]*

MARTHA: You getting angry, baby? Hunh? **(Pg 75)** *[to audience]* When our son was just a little boy he used to . . .

GEORGE: Don't, Martha . . .

MARTHA: . . . he used to throw up all the time, because of George

GEORGE: I said, don't! The real reason *[spits out the words]* our son . . . used to throw up all the time was that he couldn't stand you fiddling at him all the time, with your liquor breath on him.

MARTHA: Yeah? And I suppose that's why he ran away from home twice in one month, too. *[to audience]* Six times in one year!

GEORGE: *[to audience, matter-of-factly]* Our son ran away all the time because Martha here used to corner him. He used to run up to me when I'd get home and say, "Mama's always coming at me." That's what he'd say.

MARTHA: Liar! **(Pg 79)** *[threateningly]* You son of a . . .

GEORGE: *[quietly]* **(Pg 95)** Be careful, Martha . . . I'll rip you to pieces. **(Pg 120)** SNAP!

MARTHA: *[a little afraid]* Truth or illusion, George. Doesn't it matter to you . . . at all?

GEORGE: Now; we got one more game to play. And it's called bringing up baby.

MARTHA: **(Pg 121-123)** *[pleading]* No more games.

GEORGE: *[quietly triumphant]* One more, Martha. One more game.

MARTHA: *[almost in tears]* No more games . . . please. It's games I don't want. No more games.

GEORGE: Aw, sure you do, Martha . . . original game-girl and all, 'course you do.

MARTHA: *[tenderly; moves to touch him]* Please, George, no more games; I . . .

GEORGE: *[slapping her moving hand with vehemence]* Don't you touch me! *[grabbing her hair, pulling her head back]* Now, you listen to me, Martha; you've had quite a night for yourself,

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and you can't just cut it off whenever you've got enough blood in your mouth. I want you on your feet and slugging, sweetheart, because I'm going to knock you around, and I want you up for it. *[releases her and pushes her away]*

MARTHA: All right, George. What do you want?

GEORGE: An equal battle, baby; that's all. I want you mad

MARTHA: I'm MAD!!

GEORGE: Good -- we're going to play this one to the death.

MARTHA: Yours!

GEORGE: *[calmly]* You'd be surprised . . . **(Pg 125)** *[to audience]* Now, take our son . . .

MARTHA: George . . .

GEORGE: *[too kindly]* Yes, Martha?

MARTHA: Just what are you doing?

GEORGE: Why love, I was talking about our son.

MARTHA: Don't

GEORGE: *[to audience]* Isn't Martha something? Here we are, on the eve of our boy's homecoming, the eve of his twenty-first birthday, the eve of his majority . . . and Martha says don't talk about him. But I want to, Martha! It's very important we talk about him.

MARTHA: Just . . . don't

GEORGE: **(Pg 126)** Well, now; let's see. He's a nice kid, really, in spite of his home life; I mean, most kids'd grow up neurotic, what with Martha here carrying on the way she does: trying to break the bathroom door down to wash him in the tub when he's sixteen, because it's her baby-poo.

MARTHA: That's enough!

GEORGE: Well, do you want to take over?

MARTHA: ALL RIGHT! *[by rote; a kind of almost-tearful recitation]* Our son. You want our son? You'll have it.

GEORGE: You want a drink, Martha?

MARTHA: **(Pg 127-128)** *[from far away]* What, George?

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GEORGE: Your recitation, please . . . "Our son . . . "

MARTHA: Our son. Our son was born in September, a night not unlike tonight. . . twenty . . . one . . . years ago. It was an easy birth . . .

GEORGE: Oh, Martha; no. You labored . . . how you labored.

MARTHA: It was an easy birth . . . once it had been . . . accepted, relaxed into.

GEORGE: Ah . . . yes. Better.

MARTHA: I was young, and he was a healthy child, a red, bawling child . . .

GEORGE: *[to audience]* Martha thinks she saw him at delivery . . .

MARTHA: . . . with a full head of black hair which later, later, became blond as the sun, our son.

GEORGE: He was a healthy child.

MARTHA: And I had wanted a child. . . oh, I had wanted a child.

GEORGE: *[prodding her]* A son? A daughter?

MARTHA: A child! *[quieter]* A child. And I had my child.

GEORGE: Our child.

MARTHA: *[with great sadness]* Our child. And we raised him . . . *[laughs, briefly, bitterly]* yes, we did; we raised him . . .

GEORGE: With teddy bears and an antique bassinet from Austria . . . and *no nurse*.

MARTHA: . . . with teddy bears and a pale blue bed with cane at the headboard, cane which he wore through . . . finally . . . with his little hands . . . in his . . . sleep . . .

GEORGE: . . . nightmares . . . *[soft chuckle, head-shaking in disbelief]*

MARTHA: . . . *sleep* . . . He was a restless child . . . and animal crackers, and the bow and arrow he kept under his bed. . .

GEORGE: Why? Why, Martha?

MARTHA: . . . for fear . . . for fear of . . .

GEORGE: For fear. Just that: for fear.

MARTHA: **(Pg 129-132)** *[vaguely waving him off; going on]* And as he grew . . . he walked between us . . . *[spreads her hands]*. . . a hand out to each of us for what we could offer by way of support, affection, teaching, even love . . . and these hands, still, to hold us off a bit,

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for mutual protection, to protect us all from George's . . . . weakness . . . and my greater strength . . . to protect himself . . . and *us*. So wise. Of course, this state, this perfection . . . couldn't last. Not with George . . . not with George around.

GEORGE: *[to audience]* There; you see? I knew she'd shift.

MARTHA: A drowning man takes down those nearest. George tried, but, oh, God, how I fought him.

GEORGE: *[a satisfied laugh]*Ahhhhhhh. How did I try, Martha? How did I try?

MARTHA: How did you . . . what? No! No . . . he grew . . . our son grew . . . up; he is grown up; he is away at school, college. He is fine, everything is fine.

GEORGE: *[mocking]* Oh, come on Martha! You can't cut a story off like that, sweetheart. You started to say something . . . now you say it!

MARTHA: No!

GEORGE: Well, I **will**. *[to audience]* You see, Martha stops just when the going gets good. Now, Martha here, is a misunderstood little girl; she really is. She has a tiny problem with liquors – she can't get enough . . .

MARTHA: *[without energy]* No more, George.

GEORGE: . . . and on top of all that she has a son who fought her every inch of the way, who didn't want to be turned into a weapon against his father, who didn't want to be used as a goddamn club whenever Martha didn't get things like she wanted them!

MARTHA: *[rising to it]* Lies! Lies !!

GEORGE: Lies? All right. A son who would ***not*** disown his father, who came to him for advice, for information, for love that wasn't mixed with sickness – and you know what I mean, Martha! – who could not tolerate the slashing, braying residue that called itself his MOTHER. MOTHER? HAH!!

MARTHA: *[cold]* A son who was so ashamed of his father he asked me once if it – possibly – wasn't true, as he had heard, from some cruel boys, maybe, that he was not our child; who could not tolerate the shabby failure his father had become . . .

GEORGE: Lies!

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MARTHA: Lies? Who would not bring his girlfriends to the house . . .

GEORGE: . . . in shame of his mother . . .

MARTHA: . . . of his father! A son who spends his summers away from his family on any pretext because he can't stand the shadow of a man flickering around the edges of a house . . .

GEORGE: . . . who spends his summers away because there isn't room for him in a house full of empty bottles, lies, and strange men . . .

MARTHA: Liar!! The one thing I've tried to carry unscathed through the sewer of this marriage, through the derision and the laughter . . . through one failure after another; the one person I have tried to protect, to raise above the mire of this vile crushing marriage; the one light in all this hopeless ***darkness*** . . . our son.

GEORGE: **(Pg 133-134)** Ho-ho! Got a little surprise for you, baby. I'M RUNNING THIS SHOW! Sweetheart, I'm afraid I've got some bad news for you . . . for us, of course. Some rather sad news.

MARTHA: *[afraid, suspicious]* What is this?

GEORGE: *[oh, so patiently]* Well, Martha, while you were out of the room, I don't know where, hell, you must have been somewhere *[little laugh]* the doorbell rang . . . It's hard to tell you, Martha . . .

MARTHA: *[a strange throaty voice]* Tell me.

GEORGE: It was good old Western Union. A telegram for us. Martha . . . I can hardly bring myself to say it . . . *[sighing heavily]* **(Pg 135-136)** Martha . . . I'm afraid our boy isn't coming home for his birthday.

MARTHA: Of course he is. I say he is!

GEORGE: Martha *[long pause]* our son is . . . dead. *[silence]* He was . . . killed late in the afternoon . . . *[silence -- a tiny chuckle]* on a country road, with his learner's permit in his pocket, he swerved, to avoid a porcupine, and drove straight into a . . .

MARTHA: *[rigid fury]* YOU . . . CAN'T . . . DO . . . THAT!

GEORGE: . . . large tree. *[quietly, dispassionately]* I thought you should know.

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MARTHA: *[quivering with rage and loss]* NO! NO! YOU CANNOT DO THAT! YOU CAN'T DECIDE THAT! I WILL NOT LET YOU DECIDE THESE THINGS!

GEORGE: We'll have to leave around noon. There are matters of identification, naturally, and arrangements to be made.

MARTHA: YOU CAN'T DO THIS!

GEORGE: *[right in Martha's face]* You don't seem to understand, Martha; I haven't done anything. Now, pull yourself together. Our son is DEAD! We got a telegram; there was a car accident and he's dead. POUF! Just like that! Now, how do you like it?

MARTHA: *[a howl which weakens into a moan]* Noooooooooo. *[pathetic]* No; no, he is ***not*** dead; he is not ***dead***. You can't kill him! You can't have him die!

GEORGE: *[sarcastically]* That's right, Martha; I'm not God. I don't have the power over life and death, do I? There was a telegram.

MARTHA: Show it to me! Show me the telegram!

GEORGE: *[with a straight face]* I ate it. **(Pg 137-138)** *[with disgust]* You know the rules, Martha! For Christ's Sake, you know the rules!

MARTHA: He is our child! **GEORGE:** And I have killed him!

MARTHA: No! **GEORGE:** Yes!

MARTHA: *[great sadness and loss]* You have no right . . . you have no right at all . . .

GEORGE: *[tenderly]* I have the right, Martha. We never spoke of it; that's all. I could kill him any time I wanted to. You broke our rule. You mentioned him to someone else.

MARTHA: *[crying]* I ***forget***! I want to mention him . . . but I . . . hold on . . . I hold on . . . Oh, George, you've pushed it over the edge. You didn't have to . . . kill him. **(Pg 75)** *[to audience]* When our son was just a little boy he used to . . .

GEORGE: **(Pg 138)** *[softly]* It will be dawn soon. I think the party's over. Martha . . . time for bed.

MARTHA: You didn't have to have him die, George.

GEORGE: **(Pg 139-140)** It was time. *[long silence]* It will be better.

MARTHA: Just . . . us?

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GEORGE: Yes. Are you all right?

MARTHA: Yes . . . No.

GEORGE: *[puts his hand gently on her shoulder; she puts her head back and he sings to her, very softly]* Who's afraid of Virginia Woolf, Virginia Woolf, Virginia Woolf

MARTHA: I am George . . . I am.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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**** Who's Afraid of the Big Bad Wolf tune can be found here***
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MLh-ZoV0aUI

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